



MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

WHY HAS PEACE PROVED SO ELUSIVE IN THE MIDDLE EAST?

*Paper 2: Conflict in the Middle East, 1945-1995 -
Key Topic 1: The birth of the state of Israel, 1945-*

63

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale		
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT 1.0: Foundational Geography & Geopolitics: Why the Middle East Ignited			
L2: KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949			
L3: KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis			
L4: KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT 1.0: Foundational Geography & Geopolitics: Why the Middle East Ignited

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyse how the Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916) and League of Nations mandates drew artificial straight lines across former Ottoman territories.
- ☐ Evaluate the contradictory British wartime pledges: the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence (1915) versus the Balfour Declaration (1917).
- ☐ Identify the 4 strategic flashpoints of the Arab-Israeli conflict: Maritime Chokepoints, Elevated High Ground, Freshwater Basins, and Jerusalem.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which three continents intersect at the Middle East, making it a critical strategic crossroads throughout world history?

What vital maritime waterway, completed in 1869 across Egypt, connects the Mediterranean Sea directly to the Red Sea?

What narrow body of water at the southern tip of the Sinai Peninsula controls maritime access to the Gulf of Aqaba and Israel's southern port of Eilat?

Which elevated volcanic plateau in south-western Syria directly overlooks the Sea of Galilee and northern Israeli civilian settlements?

Which freshwater river forms the natural eastern boundary of the West Bank, flowing south from the Sea of Galilee into the Dead Sea?

Which ancient city is considered a sacred holy sanctuary by Jews, Christians, and Muslims, and claimed as a capital by both Israelis and Palestinians?

Which vast triangular desert peninsula connecting Africa to Asia served as a major military buffer zone between Egypt and Israel?

What secret agreement in May 1916 saw British and French diplomats use a ruler to carve the collapsing Ottoman Empire into European spheres of influence?

What official British letter in November 1917 promised British support for the establishment of a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine?

Why is military control of "high ground" like the Golan Heights considered an indispensable defense asset in modern warfare?

Vocabulary Check

Write a short paragraph using at least *FOUR* of the vocabulary words below correctly.

Sykes-Picot Agreement Mandate Balfour Declaration Zionism Arab Nationalism Chokepoint Contested Territory
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Q1. Explain why the Sykes-Picot Agreement and League of Nations mandates created artificial borders in the Middle East.

Q2. Explain the fundamental contradiction between the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence and the Balfour Declaration.

Q3. Why were the Golan Heights and the Straits of Tiran of supreme strategic importance in the Arab-Israeli wars?

Map Task: The Geopolitical Landscape

Understanding the geography of the Middle East is the essential first step to understanding its history. The borders of the modern Middle East were largely drawn by Britain and France following the collapse of the Ottoman Empire at the end of the First World War. These artificially imposed borders laid the groundwork for decades of instability.

At the heart of the conflict are several highly contested regions: the Gaza Strip, the West Bank, the Golan Heights, and the Sinai Peninsula. Additionally, control over strategic waterways—like the Suez Canal, the Straits of Tiran, and the River Jordan—has repeatedly triggered military escalation.

Pair & Share Activity

Q4. Prompt: Discuss with your partner: Why is the geography of the Middle East so geopolitically important?

Think: Spend 1 minute quietly considering the question and forming your own opinion.

Your Notes:

Map Task: The Geopolitical Landscape

Source A

Reference Map



Scaffolding & Hints:

- Look carefully at the coastal outlines to locate the Mediterranean and Red Seas.
- Remember that the Sinai Peninsula connects Africa to Asia.

Q5. Using the blank map provided in your workbook (or the interactive map here), label the following: - Countries: Israel, Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq, Iran - Capitals: Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, Cairo, Damascus, Amman, Beirut - Waterways: Suez Canal, Straits of Tiran, Gulf of Aqaba, Red Sea, River Jordan, Mediterranean Sea - Contested Zones (shade these): Sinai Peninsula, Golan Heights, Gaza Strip, West Bank

Q6. Explain why control over the physical geography of the Middle East (specifically the Straits of Tiran and the Golan Heights) made military conflict between Israel and Arab states almost inevitable between 1948 and 1973.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

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Pupil Voice

What was the most significant event or decision in today's lesson, and what was its major historical consequence?

General Notes

[illegible]

L2: KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the conflicting interests and demands of Jews and Arabs within the British Mandate.
- ☐ Analyze the key events leading to the end of the British Mandate, partition and the creation of Israel, including the significance of the bombing of the King David Hotel and UN Resolution 181.
- ☐ Describe the key events of the Arab-Israeli war (1948–49).

Q1. Source Detective: Why did the Irgun target the British administrative and military headquarters at the King David Hotel, and how did this attack convince the British government that maintaining the Mandate was untenable?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which secret 1916 agreement between Britain and France partitioned the Middle East into European spheres of influence?

What official British declaration in November 1917 supported the establishment of a Jewish national home in Palestine?

What international body granted Britain the official Mandate to govern Palestine in 1920?

What was the political movement founded by Theodor Herzl aiming to create a sovereign Jewish homeland?

Why was the Suez Canal of supreme imperial importance to Great Britain?

What narrow maritime strait at the mouth of the Gulf of Aqaba links Israel's port of Eilat to the Red Sea?

Which elevated plateau overlooking Galilee was a major source of border clashes between Syria and Israel?

Which three world religions consider the Old City of Jerusalem sacred?

What freshwater river forms the natural boundary between the West Bank and Jordan?

What vast desert peninsula connects Africa to Asia and borders southern Palestine?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Mandate Zionism Irgun Nakba
--

Your Sentence:

Q2. What was the 'dual obligation' that Britain faced under the League of Nations Mandate of Palestine?

Q3. Identify two reasons why Foreign Secretary Ernest Bevin set a strict immigration quota of 1,500 Jewish immigrants per month.

Q4. What was the 'Jewish Insurgency' and which three Zionist groups united to launch it?

Q5. Describe the deadliest act of the insurgency on 22 July 1946 and explain its intended target.

Q6Source Detective: Why was this attack a decisive turning point in Britain's willingness to remain in Palestine?

Q7. How did the British public react to the 'Sergeants Affair', and what was the political result?

Q8Source Detective: How did Britain's decision to forcibly deport Holocaust survivors back to displaced persons camps in Europe destroy British diplomatic standing in the United States?

Q9. How did the United Nations Partition Plan (Resolution 181) divide the land of Palestine, and what was the reaction of the two communities?

Q10. What was the impact of the Deir Yassin massacre on the Palestinian Arab population in April 1948?

Q11Source Detective: Why did Ben-Gurion choose to declare independence beneath the portrait of Theodor Herzl on the exact afternoon British forces withdrew?

Q12. Describe the tactical advantage Israel gained during the first UN truce in June 1948.

Q13. Explain the conflicting historical views regarding the displacement of over 700,000 Palestinians during the 1948 war.

Pair & Share Activity

Q14. Prompt: If you were the British government in 1945, exhausted by WWII and facing attacks from Jewish paramilitaries, what would you have done with

the Mandate?

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over Plan Dalet

Historians sharply disagree on the nature of Plan D. Traditional Israeli historians argue it was a purely defensive necessity to secure besieged Jewish settlements before the Arab armies invaded. However, 'New Historians' like Ilan Pappé argue the text of Plan D proves it was a deliberate blueprint for the systematic ethnic cleansing of Palestinian Arabs from the future Jewish state.

Q15. How does Pappé's interpretation of Plan Dalet fundamentally change our understanding of the Palestinian refugee crisis?

EXIT TICKET: THE THREE-TIERED GOLDEN SENTENCE

EXIT TICKET · THE GOLDEN SENTENCE

Write ****ONE** single, grammatically sophisticated historical sentence****** explaining why Great Britain decided to abandon its Mandate of Palestine in 1947. Your sentence **MUST** strictly contain all three required ingredients:

- Ingredient 1 (Date / Stat): Include one precise date or statistic [e.g., July 1946, 91 deaths, £100 million mandate cost, or Resolution 181].
- Ingredient 2 (Individual / Group): Name one key historical individual or group [e.g., Ernest Bevin, the Irgun, Menachem Begin, or UNSCOP].
- Ingredient 3 (Causal Conjunction): Connect your cause and effect using an analytical conjunction [e.g., consequently, provoked by, culminating in, or whereas].

Teacher Guidance: Ensure your sentence clearly shows cause and effect, not just a list of facts.

Pupil Response:

GCSE Exam Practice

Q16. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of 1945–48 which led to the creation of Israel. [8 marks • 10 mins]

[8 marks • 10 mins]

Planning your narrative account:

Remember to link your paragraphs chronologically. You could use these sentence starters:

- *The first key event was...*
- *This directly led to...*
- *Consequently, this triggered...*
- *This situation culminated in...*

[illegible]

Q17. Explain one consequence of the bombing of the King David Hotel (1946).



Pupil Voice

What was the most important change that occurred during this period, and what remained continuous (the same)?

General Notes

[illegible]

L3: KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the territorial changes and their impact, including the refugee status of Palestinian Arabs.
- ☐ Understand the creation of the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) and the Law of Return (1950), and the importance of US aid to Israel.
- ☐ Analyze Israel's relations with Egypt in the aftermath of the war.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which international organisation was given responsibility for deciding the future of Palestine in 1947?

What was the number of the UN Partition Plan passed on 29 November 1947 dividing Palestine?

What percentage of Mandatory Palestine was allocated to the proposed Jewish state under Resolution 181?

What status was proposed for the city of Jerusalem under the 1947 UN Partition Plan?

How did Arab leaders and the Arab Higher Committee respond to UN Resolution 181?

On what date did David Ben-Gurion officially proclaim the declaration of the State of Israel?

What occurred on the day immediately following Israel's declaration of independence?

What was the Jewish paramilitary force that formed the foundation of the newly created Israeli Defence Forces (IDF)?

What Jewish militant group bombed the British headquarters at the King David Hotel in July 1946?

Which European superpower provided crucial initial diplomatic recognition and permitted Czech arms shipments to Israel in 1948?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Green Line**

Q1Source Detective: How did the newly formed IDF successfully counter five invading Arab armies despite being heavily outnumbered in early 1948?

Q2. What happened to the remaining portions of mandate Palestine (the West Bank and Gaza Strip) following the 1948-49 war?

Q3Source Detective: How did the displacement of over 700,000 Palestinians create an unresolved humanitarian and territorial crisis that shaped every subsequent conflict?

Q4. How did the United Nations attempt to cope with the vast humanitarian emergency created by the displacement of 700,000 Palestinian Arabs?

Q5. Why did both Israel and the Arab host states refuse to permanently integrate the Palestinian refugees into their societies?

Q6Source Detective: Compare the 1949 Green Line with the 1947 UN Partition Plan: which areas did Israel capture beyond its original UN allocation?

Q7. Why was the establishment of the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) in May 1948 highly significant for Israel's internal politics and national security?

Q8. Explain the demographic impact of the 1950 Law of Return on the new State of Israel.

Q9. Why did President authorise massive emergency loans and grants to Israel in its early years?

Q10. Describe two ways that Egypt attempted to strangle Israel economically and militarily in the early 1950s.

Q11. How did David Ben-Gurion attempt to deter Fedayeen border raids, and what was the consequence?

Q12. Explain one consequence of the territorial changes following the 1948–49 Arab-Israeli war.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Pair & Share Activity

Q13. Prompt: Why do you think the well-equipped Arab armies were defeated by the newly formed Israeli Defense Forces?

Your Notes:

EXIT TICKET: SPOT THE HISTORICAL IMPOSTER

EXIT TICKET · TWO TRUTHS & ONE FALLACY

Below are three statements regarding the 1948–49 War and the refugee crisis. **Two are historically accurate facts; one is an IMPOSTER containing a classic GCSE examiner misconception.**

- Statement A: The 1949 Armistice Agreements (Green Line) left Israel in control of 78% of mandatory Palestine, significantly expanding beyond the 56% proposed in the 1947 UN Partition Plan.
- Statement B: The United Nations deployed an international military peacekeeping army in May 1948 that successfully enforced the borders of an independent Palestinian Arab state in the West Bank.
- Statement C: Under the 1950 Law of Return, every Jewish person worldwide was granted the automatic right to settle in Israel and gain citizenship, doubling Israel's population within four years.

Teacher Guidance: Task: State which statement is the imposter (A, B, or C) and write the 1-sentence historical correction explaining what actually happened.

Pupil Response:

[4 marks • 5 mins]

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Pupil Voice

How did the events or developments studied today affect different groups of people in contrasting ways?

General Notes

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L4: KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand Nasser and Egypt's leadership of the Arab world.
- ☐ Analyze the events and significance of Israeli attacks on Gaza in 1955 and Sinai in 1956.
- ☐ Evaluate the events and significance of the Suez Crisis (1956), including the formation of the United Arab Republic (UAR) in 1958.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What term do Palestinians use to describe the catastrophe of their expulsion and displacement in 1948?

Approximately how many Palestinian Arabs became refugees during the 1948–49 War?

What was the name of the de facto armistice boundary line drawn on maps in 1949?

Which neighboring Arab kingdom annexed the West Bank and East Jerusalem following the 1948 War?

Which Arab nation retained administrative military control over the Gaza Strip after 1949?

What legislation passed by Israel in 1950 granted every Jewish person worldwide the legal right to immigrate to Israel?

What was the unified national army established by David Ben-Gurion in 1948?

Which global superpower provided extensive financial loans and diplomatic backing to Israel in the early 1950s?

What was the decisive 4-week turning point in June 1948 that allowed Israel to rearm with Czech weapons?

Who served as Israel's first Prime Minister from 1948 to 1953?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Pan-Arabism | Czech Arms Deal | Nationalisation | Protocol of Sèvres | UNEF

Driven by the ideology of [.], sought to modernize Egypt. Following the [.], the West refused to fund his dam project. In retaliation, Nasser announced the [.] of the Suez Canal. This led to the secret [.] where Israel, Britain, and France invaded Egypt. The conflict ended with the deployment of [.] peacekeepers in the Sinai.

Q1 Source Detective: Look at the celebratory front page: why was the nationalisation of the canal seen across the Arab world as a historic victory over Western imperialism?

Q2. What were Gamal Abdel Nasser's immediate political and domestic objectives after taking power in Egypt?

Q3. Why did Israel launch a devastating reprisal raid on the Gaza Strip on 28 February 1955, and what was the result?

Q4. What was the significance of the 1955 Czech Arms Deal for the balance of power in the Middle East?

Q5Source Detective: How did Nasser use the revenue of the canal to fund the construction of the Aswan High Dam after Western loans were cancelled?

Q6. How did President Nasser respond when the United States and Great Britain abruptly withdrew their funding for the Aswan High Dam?

Q7. What was the secret Protocol of Sèvres in October 1956?

Q8. Explain how Britain and France planned to use an Israeli invasion of the Sinai as a pretext to retake the Suez Canal.

Q9Source Detective: Why did Britain and France claim they were entering Egypt as neutral peacekeepers to separate Israeli and Egyptian armies when the Sèvres Protocol proved they had pre-planned the war together?

Q10. Why did the Anglo-French-Israeli conspiracy backfire and end in a humiliating retreat?

Q11. Identify two vital security guarantees Israel received in exchange for withdrawing its forces from the Sinai Peninsula.

Q12. Explain one consequence of the nationalisation of the Suez Canal in 1956.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Pair & Share Activity

Q13. Prompt: Why was the Suez Canal so important to Britain and France that they were willing to go to war over it?

Your Notes:

EXIT TICKET: THE CAUSAL BALANCE SCALE

EXIT TICKET • THE CAUSAL BALANCE SCALE

Weigh the historical outcome of the 1956 Suez Crisis on a scale of 0 to 10 for Egypt and Gamal Abdel Nasser:

- [0] A Catastrophic Military Defeat: Israel crushed the Egyptian army in Sinai; Britain and France occupied Port Said.
- [5] A Stalemate: Egypt lost military assets, but forced an imperial withdrawal.
- [10] An Historic Political Triumph: Nasser humiliated Britain and France, kept the canal, and became the undisputed leader of the Arab world.

Teacher Guidance: Task: Where on the scale (0 to 10) do you place the outcome for Nasser, and what is your SINGLE decisive piece of historical evidence from today's lesson justifying your score?

Pupil Response:

[4 marks • 5 mins]

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Pupil Voice

What piece of historical evidence (e.g. government record, personal diary, photograph) would be most valuable to investigate today's enquiry, and why?

General Notes

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End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Paper 2: Conflict in the Middle East (1945–1995)

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)

GCSE Exam Practice: Question Bank

Choose an exam question from the bank below and answer it on the blank lined pages that follow.

From KT 1.0: Foundational Geography & Geopolitics: Why the Middle East Ignited

Q. Using the blank map provided in your workbook (or the interactive map here), label the following: - Countries: Israel, Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq, Iran - Capitals: Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, Cairo, Damascus, Amman, Beirut - Waterways: Suez Canal, Straits of Tiran, Gulf of Aqaba, Red Sea, River Jordan, Mediterranean Sea - Contested Zones (shade these): Sinai Peninsula, Golan Heights, Gaza Strip, West Bank

1. Explain why control over the physical geography of the Middle East (specifically the Straits of Tiran and the Golan Heights) made military conflict between Israel and Arab states almost inevitable between 1948 and 1973.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

From KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949

Q.. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of 1945–48 which led to the creation of Israel.

1. Explain one consequence of the bombing of the King David Hotel (1946).

From KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis

Q.. Explain one consequence of the territorial changes following the 1948–49 Arab-Israeli war.

1. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the 1948–49 Arab-Israeli War. You may use the following in your answer: • The United Nations truce (June 1948) • The unification of the IDF and Czech arms supplies You must also use information of your own.

From KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963

Q.. Explain one consequence of the Suez Crisis (1956) for the Middle East.

1. Explain the importance of the Suez Crisis (1956) for regional tension in the Middle East.

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